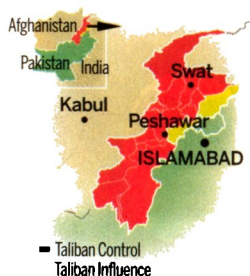


Taking on the TALIBAN

Under immense pressure from the world and within, Pakistan bites the bullet and declares war on the Taliban. Can its army succeed?



By Hasan Zaidi in the North-West Frontier Province

Driving up to the picturesque plains of Swabi and Mardan districts which border the hilly Malakand Division in the Frontier Province, amid fields of threshed wheat, one can almost be oblivious to what lies ahead. Almost, because the signs of war are also all around. Convoys of military personnel speed towards the battle zone, with machine guns mounted and manned atop army trucks. On the railway tracks, rows after rows of tanks are also bound for the same place. All clear signs of the Pakistan Army's biggest offensive in recent times in the region to go after Taliban fighters in what President Asif Zardari has termed as "a battle for the soul of Pakistan".

TALIBAN FIGHTERS IN BUNER; (EXTREME RIGHT) A PAKISTAN ARMY TANK IN ACTION



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